But Hinduism is no monolith; its strength is found within each Hindu, not in the collectivity. Defining a 'Hindu' cause may well be a political reaction to the definition of non-Hindu causes: the Hindutva idea originated around the same time as the rise of a separate Muslim consciousness in the polity in the early twentieth century, and the resentments that spilled over into the destruction of the Babri Masjid in the century's last decade were largely articulated in opposition to the imagined 'appeasement' of India's minorities. The rage of the Hindu mobs is that of those who feel themselves supplanted in this competition of identities, who think that they are taking their country back from usurpers of long ago. They want revenge against history, but they do not realise that history is its own revenge.

The Hindutva fanatics seek to reinvent Hindu identity with a new belief structure and a new vocabulary. They seek to make Hinduism more like the Semitic religions they resent but wish to emulate: to pick fewer sacred books, notably the Gita, and exalt them would produce a less 'baggy', tighter version of the faith; to focus on fewer gods, notably Shiva, Rama and Krishna, with Ganesh and various forms of Devi thrown in, would sharpen Hindu divinity; to standardise religious practices around specific familiar festivals, rituals and gatherings, would provide a greater sense of community. Their associated efforts include a desire to control and restrict what Hindus eat, so their rejection of beef (even though several castes did eat it in the past) would itself become a marker of identity; to promote Hindi as a national language (though it is quite foreign to nearly half the country) so as to ensure that the vocabulary of Hindudom can be more easily transmitted; to mouth the same slogans ('Bharat Mata ki Jai!') and chant the same songs ('Vande Mataram' is a must), even though some Muslims are uncomfortable with both, in order to promote conformity. This invented Hinduism has much more to do with an era of political and cultural insecurity and a faltering new sense of aspiration than with the Vedas, the *Purana*s or the Bhakti movement: it denies the lived history of Hinduism even while claiming to speak in its name.

The central challenge of India is the challenge of accommodating the aspirations of different groups in the national dream. The ethos of